ONE-PAGE PREACHING OUTLINE

The Valley Breathes

Ezekiel · Ezekiel 37:1–14

Primary text: Ezekiel 37:1–14 **Also read:** Ezekiel 36:22–38 · 34:1–31 · 37:15–28 · Daniel 12:1–3 · John 11:17–27 · Romans 8:1–11 · Ephesians 2:1–10 **Big idea:** God is not intimidated by a valley of dry bones. His word assembles the dead, His Spirit gives them breath, and the risen King leads them home. **Time:** 55–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response (6,810 words at about 120 wpm). **Aim:** From hiding the bones to naming them; from self-rescue to the God who raises the dead.

MOVEMENT MAP

MIN	SECTION	BEATS AND TRANSITION
5	**Introduction: The valley full of bones**	Ezekiel in Babylon. A valley, not a cemetery: bones on the surface, very many, very dry. No mourners, no names. "Son of man, can these bones live?" "O Lord GOD, you know." → *"Can these bones live?"*
7	**The death we cannot deny**	Exile: deported in 597 BC; Jerusalem falls in 586. They settle, then despair: "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost" (37:11). The bones are not tired; they are dry. → *"Tell the truth about the bones."*
8	**The question we cannot answer**	God asks what He already knows. The question is a mirror. Optimism says, "We can fix it." Despair says, "It is over." Both put the answer in our hands. Ezekiel hands the impossible to God: "You know." Faith looks at the deadness, then at God (Gen 18:14; Jer 32:17; Rom 4:17–21). → *"Hand Him the impossible."*
8	**The word we cannot manufacture**	"Prophesy over these bones." No ears, no lungs, no congregation. The word is not a suggestion: "I will cause breath to enter you." Bone to bone; sinews, flesh, skin. Then the pause: assembled, but no breath. A warning against religion without the Spirit. → *"Preach; God quickens."*
8	**The breath we cannot command**	"Prophesy to the breath." Ruach: wind, breath, Spirit. Creation language (Gen 2:7); the four winds; the dead stand as an exceedingly great army. We cannot command the wind, but we can pray for it. Word and Spirit are both necessary. → *"Pray for the wind."*
7	**The graves He will open**	The bones are the whole house of Israel; the graves are exile. Cyrus, 538 BC, the return; the second temple is smaller, the glory does not fill it. Daniel 12 and Isaiah 26 reach further. Jesus is the true Israel, buried and raised; He breathes the Spirit (John 20:22; Acts 2). Ephesians 2: dead, then made alive. → *"The graves will open."*
6	**Application: What do you do in the valley?**	Tell God the truth about the bones. Stop asking dead bones to save themselves. Speak the word and pray for the wind. Do not settle for an assembled corpse. Grace first; then obedience. Resurrection is for walking. → *"Do both."*
3	**The invitation**	Three people: the one in the valley; the one assembled but breathless; the one who has given up on someone else. All need the same Savior. The gospel is not that the valley is not real; it is that God entered it. → *"Come to the living Lord."*
5	**Response and closing**	Silence. Three questions: where are the bones, what would honesty look like, who needs your word and prayer? One faithful step this week. Care note (988 in the US). Prayer. The tomb is empty. The valley breathes. → *"Look at the tomb."*

Total: 57 minutes; 55–60 with normal variation.

LINES TO LAND

- "The bones are not tired. They are dry."
- "Faith does not deny the deadness; it looks at the deadness and then looks at God."
- "The body was assembled. There was no breath in it."
- "The valley does not breathe because the bones try harder."
- "The tomb is empty. The valley breathes."

GUARDRAILS

- Do not reduce the vision to a metaphor for discouragement; the bones are Israel in exile.
- Keep the return from Babylon primary. Do not claim Ezekiel 37 directly predicts Jesus' resurrection without the canonical steps.
- Do not merge "son of man" in Ezekiel with Daniel 7 or with Jesus' title without noting the difference.
- Do not promise every valley will end on your timetable; the text promises God can raise the dead.
- The gospel must be explicit: the cross, the empty tomb, and the Spirit. Do not end on "try harder."
- Care note: do not tell suffering people to "just believe harder"; include the crisis line.

IF YOU MUST CUT

- **To 50 minutes:** trim 7 minutes; keep 37:3–5, 37:8–10, the ruach wordplay, 37:11–14, and the empty tomb.